eyes on, and the last of many who let her down. She asked him to kill her but Adhar refused. Furious at his ‘soft heart’, writes Abul Fazl, the rani drew out her dagger and committed her final act of courage upon herself, on her own.

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A thousand elephants and ‘much other booty’ fell to Asaf Khan,[25] but this was nothing to the treasure that was to come. Bir Sah had fled to the fort of Chauragarh, long a base for Gond rulers and repository for their treasure. Two months later, Asaf Khan’s troops arrived at his gates, the young king was killed, and the Mughal soldiers found themselves arms-deep in riches worthy of legend, including 100 literal pots of gold.[26] Four days into their delighted exploration of the fort, the conquerors made a more grisly discovery. Opening yet another door, they found a room full of charred bodies.

Like Baz Bahadur in Malwa, Bir Sah rode out to his final battle leaving two men behind – Bhoj Kayath and Mian Bhikari Rumi – with orders to organize a jauhar of the women in the fort should he lose the fight. They lit a fire – Bhoj beheading, besides, any woman who protested her fate – and, in Abul Fazl’s words, ‘that harvest of roses [was] . . . reduced to ashes’.

Two buds survived the carnage. One was an unnamed princess, the other was Rani Durgavati’s sister, Kamlavati. Both were hiding behind a piece of wood so large that it saved rather than burnt them. The two royal women were sent to Akbar’s court, along with a measly tribute of 200 elephants – and not a single jewel.

Much like Adham, Asaf Khan did not seem to think that the fruits of his labour belonged to the throne. This time, however, Akbar paid no mind. Commanders coy about parting with their spoils were less of an emergency, after all, than warlords in full-fledged rebellion.

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Abul Fazl doesn’t record the date, but Rani Durgavati is generally believed to have killed herself on 24 June 1564. Akbar may not have heard of her defeat – and certainly not of the plunder at Chauragarh, which took place a full two months later – when, on 1 July 1564, for the second time in three